serving in the United Provinces, now Uttar Pradesh. After retirement, Babuji, as he was affectionately called, had settled into a nice little bungalow on 6th lane, Prabhat Road, a leafy, tree-lined avenue in Pune. He used to live alone with a trusted man Friday, my grandmother having passed when my father was quite young. On the maternal side, my grandfather, Shripad Ramachandra Parasnis, had been a senior and respected professor at Fergusson College, Pune, and a founder member of the Deccan Education Society, until his career was cut short due to an accident with, of all things, an Army truck of the National Defence Academy, which would in time become my alma mater and I, the Army Chief. What irony. My grandfather and grandmother Shalini (née Deshpande) used to stay at Karve Road, Pune, near Nal Stop, so called because there used to be a public water tap (*nal*) there. Though they were our grandparents, all of us cousins, for some unknown reason, used to call them Ai and Dada.

My distinct memory of Gwalior was of going to school, or it must have been pre-school, in a cycle rickshaw that had a wire-mesh cage, with a door at the rear. Two such rickshaws would come to our house, in the officers' residential area, to cart all of us children off to school. On one occasion, I had got into one of the rickshaws and my brother in another, and not wanting to be separated, I tried to get out, but just then the rickshaw-wallah accidentally slammed the door shut on my hand. There was much confusion and wailing and I had to be rushed to the infirmary, but thankfully no damage was done, and I did get a day off from school. I also vaguely remember a row of houses along a dusty street. My sister and brother, being a few years older, would be getting into all kinds of mischief, with me as their unwitting accomplice. Whenever they used to get scolded for various acts of naughtiness, I used to innocently wander off,

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